

Hello, spreadsheet

Working with DC 311 service requests

■ Spreadsheet Basics

- Rows, Columns and Cells
- Ideally, each row describes one “thing”
 - A Supercan delivery request
 - An out-of-state parking violation
 - A missed trash collection
- Headers
- Text Left, Numbers (and Dates) Right
 - WARD reads as text; SERVICECALLCOUNT is a real number.

REPORTING FINDING

ZIPCODE sorts to the right like a number — but it's a label. Don't do math on it, and watch for dropped leading zeros.

■ Entering Data

- Decide on columns first, then type a few rows to be sure
- Decide on abbreviations — or when you need to make things very clear
- Try to type as little as possible

The 311 file ships both - a short code and a human-readable label:

SERVICECODE

S0422



SERVICECODEDESCRIPTION

Supercan - Delivery



DC 311 Service Requests

Let's explore some real service requests:

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/15D8pgZwmZVi18fP0STSmGh6RIHFgEhTI1PXN_nFUwG4/edit?gid=2143103363#gid=2143103363

■ Sorting

- The goal is to put things in some order
- Can be used to find things, but you should not rely on it for that
- Sort order: blanks, spaces, numbers, letters
 - If the result looks otherwise, you probably have leading spaces
- Preserve original order with an ID column
 - 311 already has OBJECTID — a built-in sequential ID to sort back to.

REPORTING FINDING

Sorting ADDDATE looks chronological — but it's stored as text:

2026/03/25 04:00:18+00

You're sorting strings, not dates — and there's a hidden UTC offset along for the ride.

■ Filtering

- The goal is to find things
- How you do that is up to you
 - Exact matches
 - Fuzzy matches — “Closed” alone misses “Closed (Duplicate)”
 - Ranges for numbers / dates
- You can “save” filter results, but don’t
 - Too easy to turn off — make a copy of the results instead.

REPORTING FINDING

Filter on PRIORITY: 9,128 of 9,153 rows are “Standard.”

When a field is one value 99.7% of the time, is it telling you anything?

■ Basic Functions

- The goal is to create new information from existing data
- Two basic kinds of functions
 - Mathematical
 - String
 - (But both are mathematical)
- Two very basic roles of operators
 - Operations on numbers
 - Operations on text

TRY IT

Turn “Ward 7” into a clean ward number — or count requests per ward.

(Strings get their own deck next.)